

Are Voters Motivated by Policy Preferences or Partisan Identities?

Replication of Schonfield and Winter-Levy (2021)

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Schonfeld, B., & Winter-Levy, S. (2021). Policy or Partisanship in the United Kingdom? Quasi-Experimental Evidence from Brexit. *The Journal of Politics*, 83(4), 1450–1461. <https://doi.org/10.1086/712143>

Context: Research Focus & Design

Puzzle and Research Question

Key Question: Are voters primarily motivated by their partisan identity or policy preferences?

- Answer has **relevance** for theories of ideological responsiveness, political representation, and democratic accountability
- Despite **decades of research**, this is an **ongoing debate**

Prior Literature: Two Main Arguments

- **'Party over Policy'** = voters update their political views (& answers to factual question) to match their political party
- **'Policy over Party'** = voters care more about their genuine policy preferences than party labels; may switch parties in case of severe disagreement

Methodological Challenges: Disentangling voters' partisanship from their policy preferences is difficult outside of lab settings

- endogeneity and selection challenges
- "partisan intoxication" and policy voting tend to be **observationally equivalent**
- exact nature of the relationship between partisanship and policy preferences remains unclear

How to overcome these challenges?

Methodological Challenges

Potential solution: study **party realignments**

- can occur when a major party **changes their policy position rapidly and significantly**
- supporters can **either disregard their policy preference** and continue to back the party, or **change their voting behavior**
- **Problem:** rapid changes in a party's policy position are rare

⇒ **Schonfield and Winter-Levy (2021)** exploit one of these rare events for their research design

The Aftermath of the **2016 Brexit referendum** in the United Kingdom:

- After the unexpected outcome: Conservative Party **repositioned** itself as a pro-Brexit party **within a matter of days**
- **Leave vs. Remain:** “was not immediately subsumed into the existing party divide” (Hobolt et al., 2021, p. 1480)
⇒ **potential tension between partisan ID and policy preference**

British Election Study: Panel Data was collected shortly before and after the referendum

Research Question: Are voters primarily motivated by their partisan identity or policy preferences?

- **Data:** Wave 8 (May 6-June 22, 2016) and Wave 9 (June 24-July 4, 2016) of the British Election Study
- **Quasi-experimental set-up:** Interrupted Time Series Design
- **OLS models**
- **Test two main hypotheses:**
 - **Policy voting** hypothesis
 - **Partisan intoxication** hypothesis

Replication

What does the study test?

1. **Do policy preferences predict party-switching?**
2. Does partisanship predict changes in policy preferences?
3. Do changes in partisanship affect policy preferences?
4. Long-term effects? (Influence on vote choice)

Although the replication paper includes all models, we will **focus on the Policy Voting Hypotheses**

Hypothesis:

Pre-referendum Euroskepticism positively predicts switching from non-Conservative to Conservative and negatively predicts switching from Conservative to non-Conservative.

In other words: They expect that respondents will switch parties due to their policy preferences

Table 1: Policy Voting Hypothesis

	<i>Dependent variable: Defect from Conservatives</i>		
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Pre-Referendum Euroskepticism	-0.003* (0.001)	-0.001 (0.001)	0.0001 (0.001)
Perceived Change in Conservative Euroskepticism		0.011* (0.004)	0.009* (0.004)
Age			-0.001*** (0.0002)
Female			-0.007 (0.007)
White			-0.058** (0.019)
Scotland			0.002 (0.012)
Wales			0.021 (0.014)
Pre-referendum Euroskepticism: Perceived change in Conservative Euroskepticism		-0.001* (0.001)	-0.001* (0.001)
Constant	0.101*** (0.011)	0.084*** (0.011)	0.181*** (0.023)
Observations	7,330	6,476	6,216
R ²	0.001	0.001	0.006
Adjusted R ²	0.0004	0.001	0.005
Residual Std. Error	0.272 (df = 7328)	0.261 (df = 6472)	0.258 (df = 6207)
F Statistic	3.912* (df = 1; 7328)	2.709* (df = 3; 6472)	4.554*** (df = 8; 6207)

Note:

*p<0.05; **p<0.01; ***p<0.001

Specification:

- **Outcome:** Party Switching (dichotomous)
- **Causes:** *Euroskepticism* and *Perceived Change* in party position

Finds support for Policy Voting Hypothesis

- a 1-point increase in pre-referendum Euroskepticism yields a **0.3% decrease in the probability of defection** from the Conservatives
→ within weeks of the referendum, **over 8% of Conservatives disaffiliated** from the party

Interaction term: those who were **less Euroskeptic** and **perceived** that the **party had become increasingly Euroskeptic** were especially likely to reject the party

Table 2: Policy Voting Hypothesis

	<i>Dependent variable: Joined Conservatives</i>		
	(1)	(2)	(3)
Pre-Referendum Euroskepticism	0.007*** (0.0005)	0.007*** (0.001)	0.006*** (0.001)
Perceived change in Conservative Euroskepticism		-0.003* (0.001)	-0.004** (0.001)
Age			0.0004*** (0.0001)
Female			-0.002 (0.003)
White			-0.008 (0.007)
Scotland			-0.017*** (0.005)
Wales			-0.012 (0.006)
Pre-referendum Euroskepticism: Perceived change in Conservative Euroskepticism		0.001*** (0.0002)	0.001*** (0.0002)
Constant	-0.001 (0.003)	0.00004 (0.004)	-0.007 (0.009)
Observations	18,517	15,139	14,554
R ²	0.012	0.015	0.017
Adjusted R ²	0.012	0.015	0.017
Residual Std. Error	0.198 (df = 18515)	0.204 (df = 15135)	0.202 (df = 14545)
F Statistic	216.857*** (df = 1; 18515)	78.431*** (df = 3; 15135)	31.854*** (df = 8; 14545)

Note:

*p<0.05; **p<0.01; ***p<0.001

Specification:

- **Outcome:** Party Switching (dichotomous)
- **Causes:** *Euroskepticism* and *Perceived Change* in party position

Finds support for Policy Voting Hypothesis

- a 1-point increase in pre-referendum Euroskepticism generates a **0.7% increase in the probability of switching loyalties** to the Conservatives.
→ **4% of respondents** who did not back the Conservatives (pre-referendum) switched to the party

Interaction term: those who were **more Euroskeptic** and **perceived** that the **party had become increasingly Euroskeptic** were especially likely to join the party

Extension

Three Extensions:

1. **Party ID Strength: Who switches their political affiliation?**
2. Logistic models
3. Alternative measure of Euroskepticism

Extension 1: Party ID Strength

Why Party ID Strength Should Matter

- Conclude: Voters are **"sufficiently" policy-motivated**
- **Electoral volatility** has increased in the UK
 - created "a larger pool of unattached and changeable voters susceptible to party responses to the EU referendum" (Griffiths et al., 2025, p. 157)

Hence: **Unattached voters should be more likely to update their partisan identification** based on the Conservatives' repositioning as a pro-Brexit party than voters with strong partisan attachments

Extension 1: Party ID Strength

Specification:

- **Outcome:** Party Switching (Binary)
- Added Variable: Party ID Strength

Party ID Strength:

- categorical variable with three levels
→ "strong", "fairly strong", and "not very strong"
- Measured pre-referendum

Extension 1: Defect

	<i>Dependent variable: Defection from the Conservatives</i>	
	(1) (Original Model)	(2) (Extension)
Pre-Referendum Euroskepticism	0.0001 (0.001)	0.002 (0.001)
Perceived change in Conservative Euroskepticism	0.009** (0.004)	0.007* (0.004)
Party ID Strength: Fairly strong		0.016* (0.008)
Party ID Strength: Not very strong		0.129**** (0.010)
Age	-0.001**** (0.0002)	-0.001**** (0.0002)
Female	-0.007 (0.007)	-0.011* (0.007)
White	-0.058*** (0.019)	-0.063**** (0.018)
Scotland	0.002 (0.012)	0.007 (0.012)
Wales	0.021 (0.014)	0.019 (0.013)
Pre-referendum Euroskepticism: perceived change in Conservative Euroskepticism	-0.001** (0.001)	-0.001* (0.001)
Constant	0.181**** (0.023)	0.123**** (0.024)
Observations	6,216	6,181
R ²	0.006	0.042
Adjusted R ²	0.005	0.040
Residual Std. Error	0.258 (df = 6207)	0.252 (df = 6170)
F Statistic	4.554**** (df = 8; 6207)	26.885**** (df = 10; 6170)

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01; ****p<0.001 ;

Extension 1: Defection - Interpretation

Coefficients:

- Perceived Change: 0.007* ($\downarrow$ from 0.009**)
- Fairly Strong: 0.016*
- **Not Very Strong: 0.129*****
- Interaction: -0.001* (from - 0.001**)

Interpretation: In comparison to strongly attached partisans, **weakly attached Conservative partisans** are **more likely to defect** from the Party after its shift on Brexit (**12.9%**), even when accounting for other explanations

→ Difference in magnitude of effect

Extension 1: Join

	<i>Dependent variable: Joined the Conservatives</i>	
	(1)	(2)
	(Original Model)	(Extension)
Pre-Referendum Euroskepticism	0.006*** (0.001)	0.007*** (0.001)
Perceived change in Conservative Euroskepticism	-0.004** (0.001)	-0.003* (0.001)
Age	0.0004*** (0.0001)	0.0004*** (0.0001)
Female	-0.002 (0.003)	-0.006 (0.004)
White	-0.008 (0.007)	-0.003 (0.008)
Scotland	-0.017*** (0.005)	-0.013** (0.005)
Wales	-0.012 (0.006)	-0.010 (0.006)
Pre-referendum Euroskepticism: perceived change in Conservative Euroskepticism	0.001*** (0.0002)	0.001*** (0.0002)
Party ID Strength: Fairly strong		0.006 (0.004)
Party ID Strength: Not very strong		0.040*** (0.005)
Constant	-0.007 (0.009)	-0.029** (0.010)
Observations	14,554	12,829
R ²	0.017	0.026
Adjusted R ²	0.017	0.025
Residual Std. Error	0.202 (df = 14545)	0.201 (df = 12818)
F Statistic	31.854*** (df = 8; 14545)	34.279*** (df = 10; 12818)

Note:

*p<0.05; **p<0.01; ***p<0.001

Extension 1: Join - Interpretation

Coefficients:

- Euroskepticism: 0.007*** (↑ from 0.006***)
- Perceived Change: -0.003* (↑ from -0.004**)
- Fairly Strong: 0.016*
- **Not Very Strong: 0.04*****
- Interaction: 0.001***

Interpretation: Weakly attached Conservative partisans are more likely to join the Conservatives after its shift on Brexit (4%), even when accounting for other explanations

- Comparatively, more limited effect for Joining than for Defection
- higher threshold to join *another* party than merely defect?

Conclusion

Key Question: **Are voters primarily motivated by their partisan identity or policy preferences?**

- Original Paper finds **evidence for both hypotheses in some contexts**
- Euroskepticism influences Party-Switching (**Policy-Motivated**)
- But: **Partisan Identity Strength** is an important factor, too
- Different **measures of Euroskepticism** can lead to somewhat different results (next slides)

Additional Checks

Logistic Models: direction and significance of effects remains the same

Attitude vs. Behaviour:

- **Euroskepticism item:**

Some say European unification **should be pushed further** (10). Others say it has already **gone too far**(0). What is your opinion?

- **Referndum Vote Intention:**

If you do vote in the referendum on Britain's membership of the European Union, how do you think you will vote? **Leave vs. Remain**

→ Most interesting finding: Model for **Joining the Conservatives**

Extension 3: Attitude vs Behaviour

	(Original Model)	(Extension)
Pre-Referendum Euroskepticism	0.006**** (0.001)	
EU Referendum Vote Intention		0.037**** (0.004)
Perceived Change in Conservative Euroskepticism	-0.004*** (0.001)	-0.001 (0.001)
Age	0.0004**** (0.0001)	0.0004**** (0.0001)
Gender	-0.002 (0.003)	-0.003 (0.003)
White	-0.008 (0.007)	-0.007 (0.008)
Scotland	-0.017**** (0.005)	-0.016**** (0.005)
Wales	-0.012* (0.006)	-0.014** (0.006)
Pre-referendum Euroskepticism: Perceived Change in Conservative Euroskepticism	0.001**** (0.0002)	
EU Referendum Vote Intention: Perceived Change in Conservative Euroskepticism		0.007**** (0.001)
Constant	-0.007 (0.009)	0.013 (0.009)
Observations	14,554	14,124
R ²	0.017	0.017
Adjusted R ²	0.017	0.016
Residual Std. Error	0.202 (df = 14545)	0.201 (df = 14115)
F Statistic	31.854**** (df = 8; 14545)	29.773**** (df = 8; 14115)

Note:

*p<0.1; **p<0.05; ***p<0.01

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